



When people go back home, they notice how things that have changed: the stores that closed, the new buildings, the buildings that have been abandoned or torn down, the new people that have moved in.

and the old neighbors that are no longer there. Imagine only hearing stories, and then returning and finding everything in piles of rubble. Imagine finding everything totally demolished.

Going Back Home

[Ezra 1:1-11](#) *"In the first year of Cyrus king of Persia, that the word of the Lord by the mouth of Jeremiah might be fulfilled, the Lord stirred up the spirit of Cyrus king of Persia, so that he made a proclamation throughout all his kingdom and also put it in writing: 'Thus says Cyrus king of Persia: The Lord, the God of heaven, has given me all the kingdoms of the earth, and he has charged me to build him a house at Jerusalem, which is in Judah. Whoever is among you of all his people, may his God be with him, and let him go up to Jerusalem, which is in Judah, and rebuild the house of the Lord, the God of Israel—he is the God who is in Jerusalem. And let each survivor, in whatever place he sojourns, be assisted by the men of his place with silver and gold, with goods and with beasts, besides freewill offerings for the house of God that is in Jerusalem.'"*

We're going to take a look at the beginning of the book of Ezra to find out what it was like for the Israelites to return home to the land God had promised them as their heritage. We could also start with the last two verses of the book of 2 Chronicles, which are the exact same words. If you look in your Bible, you will find the book of 2 Chronicles in the middle of the first half of the Old Testament. The Bible Jesus used placed the book of 2 Chronicles as the last book.

If you look at the last two verses in 2 Chronicles, they are very, very similar to Ezra 1:1-2. Take a look:

[2Chronicles 36:22-23](#) *"Now in the first year of Cyrus king of Persia, that the word of the Lord by the mouth of Jeremiah might be fulfilled, the Lord stirred up the spirit of Cyrus king of Persia, so that he made a proclamation throughout all his kingdom and also put it in writing: 'Thus says Cyrus king of Persia, 'The Lord, the God of heaven, has given me all the kingdoms of the earth, and he has charged me to build him a house at Jerusalem, which is in Judah. Whoever is among you of all his people, may the Lord his God be with him. Let him go up.'"*

Not only are they close they are identical, except for the first word. 2 Chronicles adds the word "now" but Ezra 1:1 does not. Very likely the same person wrote both passages. Why write them twice? The return of the Jewish people to Jerusalem was a very big event for them. The Jewish people had been all but eliminated. When the Babylonians conquered Judah, and all the best and brightest people were taken into captivity, For a period of time the Jewish people were erased from every map. They might have been able to keep some sense of identity, but they had no national boundaries, no land to call their own. They were wiped off the map. It looked like they would eventually be absorbed into Babylon and would eventually lose their sense of identity as a nation. Then Cyrus issued this decree. Not only could Jewish people return to the capitol city, Jerusalem, they could rebuild the Temple, so that they could once again receive forgiveness for their sins, and live close to God. Many nations have been swallowed up by more powerful nations with greater military power but not the people of Judah and Benjamin.

A poem was written about an ancient king named "Ozymandias." He ruled over a vast kingdom, and he conquered and ruled over many nations that he defeated. The poet tells about how a statue of this king remains. All the stature, except the bottom of two of its legs, has been broken off. If you look some distance from the base of the statue, you will find, lying in the sand, a head, with a very sinister expression. If you look below the broken legs, you will find an inscription written on the base of the statue: "My name is Ozymandias, King of Kings; Look on my Works, ye Mighty, and despair!" That might have worked when Ozymandias was still living and ruling, but now, if you see this broken statue, you will see only the sands of a desert as far as you can see. The once great kingdom has been destroyed. The destroyer has been destroyed.

The Jewish people escaped the "Ozymandias syndrome". What happened to Ozymandias could have happened to them. God was with them. The Jewish people came close to seeing everything related to Judaism become a relic of history, without a future, like the once great and mighty king, Ozymandias.

God's plan for the Jewish people was not complete. Jesus had not come yet.

What Was God's Plan for His People?

The Bible reveals that God's plan at the very beginning of creation was to dwell with His people. Adam and Eve's mission began in the Garden of Eden, where they attended to things there ("The Lord God took the man and put him in the garden of Eden to work it and keep it" [Genesis 2:15](#), ESV). God's design was that eventually the number of human beings would grow and Adam and Eve, along with their descendants would fill the earth ("And God blessed them. And God said to them, 'Be fruitful and multiply and fill the earth and subdue it, and have dominion over the fish of the sea and over the birds of the heavens and over every living thing that moves on the earth.'" (Genesis 1:28, ESV). Human beings would rule over all aspects of the earth (And God blessed them. And God said to them, "Be fruitful and multiply and fill the earth and subdue it, and have dominion over the fish of the sea and over the birds of the heavens and over every living thing that moves on the earth" ([Genesis 1:28](#), ESV).

Later God's chose again to dwell with His people, this time, in the Holy Land (Deuteronomy 26:2). At first the people could draw close to God in the Tabernacle. Later a Temple was built, where the people could come to offer sacrifices for their sins. This closeness to God was not unconditional. God told His people that if they disobeyed His commands (Deuteronomy 28:15), they would be exiled from the land (Deuteronomy 28:36).

If God punished His people by sending them into exile we might wonder whether God continued to be with His people when they were in exile. The prophet Ezekiel, quotes God as saying, "Therefore say, 'Thus says the Lord God: Though I removed them far off among the nations, and though I scattered them among the countries, yet **I have been a sanctuary to them for a while in the countries where they have gone**'" [Ezekiel 11:16](#), ESV. Whether the Jewish people realized it or not, we don't know, but God revealed that even while they were in exile God Himself was a "sanctuary to them."

Beginning with the creation of Adam and Eve, God's desire has been to dwell with His people. Even when it became necessary to send His people into exile, God continued to dwell with His people.

Meanwhile

What did people in Ezra's time see when they arrived at the former site of the city of Jerusalem? After 70 years of being separated from the land God had promised them, what did they feel when they got there?

They realized they had lost a great deal. The beautiful Temple built by King Solomon was gone. Very likely, the streets in the city were torn up so badly that you couldn't tell where they had been. What had once been a beautiful city was now very ugly. Instead of streets and buildings there were piles of rubble.

The people of Ezra's time also realized that in addition to losing a lot they had a chance for a future as a nation. When we do the math, we realize that Jesus didn't come to the Jewish people for more than another 500 years after the people returned with Ezra. A lot happened during that time.

I'm going to jump ahead 500 years to the time of Jesus. Perhaps one of the proudest achievements of the Jewish people living in Jesus' time was King Herod's new Temple in Jerusalem. Even Jesus' disciples were impressed with it. If you've ever marveled at the construction of a skyscraper, a bridge, the engineering of a car, or a jet you get a sense of what they were thinking when they discussed the greatness of the Temple in Jerusalem. In Mark's Gospel we read about how the disciples were very impressed with the Temple Herod had built: "And as he came out of the temple, one of his disciples said to him, 'Look, Teacher, what wonderful stones and what wonderful buildings!' And Jesus said to him, 'Do you see these great buildings? There will not be left here one stone upon another that will not be thrown down'" ([Mark 13:1-2](#), ESV). The disciples were puffing out their chests with national pride. The Temple of Herod was huge. It was beautiful. In the minds of the Jewish people, the Temple proved the greatness of their nation's faith in the one, true God. Then, Jesus said that it was going to be destroyed, as it had been before Ezra returned to Jerusalem. What we read about in Ezra, the sadness of the Temple's destruction, would come again.

When the people of Jesus' time read Ezra's account, they puffed out their chests with pride. They saw how the people of Judah had come from Babylon to Jerusalem bringing with them all the treasures that had been stolen from Jerusalem so that they could rebuild the Temple.

As they read Ezra, they realized that this was a setback for the people of Judah, but that God had graciously given them the opportunity to return to the land and rebuild. God had punished the people for their sins, but He had forgiven them.

They realized God had not abandoned His people, even when He had punished them by sending them into exile.

The Jews living during the time of Jesus didn't realize that God was visiting them again. He wasn't coming to judge them. He was coming to offer a way for their sins to be forgiven by believing in Jesus. Through Jesus Christ they would be able to draw close to God, and live at peace with him.

Jesus assured those who believed in Him that the time would come when He would return and bring all of His people with Him to dwell with Him forever in His Father's house ("In my Father's house are many rooms. If it were not so, would I have told you that I go to prepare a place for you? And if I go and prepare a place for you, I will come again and will take you to myself, that where I am you may be also" John 14:2-3, ESV). That time is still in the future. We don't know how much longer believers will need to wait until He returns. In the meantime, all believers have the love of Christ to sustain them.

Remember the assuring words of the Apostle Paul, "neither death nor life, nor angels nor rulers, nor things present nor things to come, nor powers, nor height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus our Lord" Romans 8:38-39, ESV).

God will bring every single person who believes in Him through the ups and downs of this fallen and sinful world. Let go of everything else and hold tightly to Him as you trust Him in all things.

Do you long for a home where you can feel totally at peace with God and the universe? Are you longing to know His forgiveness of your sins? Can you believe in Jesus and trust Him to save you? If you believe in Him, He will give you a home where you can be perfectly at peace with Him for all eternity.

The Proclamation of Cyrus (Ezra 1:1–11)

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In the **first** year of **Cyrus king** of **Persia**, that the word of the **LORD** by the **mouth** of **Jeremiah** might be **fulfilled**, the **LORD** **stirred** up the **spirit** of **Cyrus king** of **Persia**, so that he made a proclamation throughout all his **kingdom** and **also** put it in writing: “Thus says **Cyrus king** of **Persia**: The **LORD**, the God of heaven, has given me all the **kingdoms** of the earth, and he has **charged** me to build him a **house** at **Jerusalem**, which is in **Judah**. Whoever is among you of all his people, may his God be with him, and let him go up to **Jerusalem**, which is in **Judah**, and **rebuild** the **house** of the **LORD**, the God of Israel—he is the God who is in **Jerusalem**. And let each survivor, in whatever **place** he sojourns, be assisted by the men of his **place** with **silver** and **gold**, with **goods** and with **beasts**, **besides** freewill **offerings** for the **house** of God that is in **Jerusalem**.” Then rose up the heads of the fathers’ **houses** of **Judah** and Benjamin, and the priests and the Levites, everyone whose **spirit** God had **stirred** to go up to **rebuild** the **house** of the **LORD** that is in **Jerusalem**. And all who were about them aided them with **vessels** of **silver**, with **gold**, with **goods**, with **beasts**, and with costly wares, **besides** all that was freely **offered**. **Cyrus** the **king** **also** **brought** out the **vessels** of the **house** of the **LORD** that Nebuchadnezzar had carried away from **Jerusalem** and **placed** in the **house** of his gods. **Cyrus king** of **Persia** **brought** these out in the **charge** of Mithredath the treasurer, who counted them out to **Sheshbazzar** the prince of **Judah**. And this was the number of them: 30 **basins** of **gold**, 1,000 **basins** of **silver**, 29 censers, 30 **bowls** of **gold**, 410 **bowls** of **silver**, and 1,000 other **vessels**; all the **vessels** of **gold** and of **silver** were 5,400. All these did **Sheshbazzar** bring up, when the exiles were **brought** up from Babylonia to **Jerusalem**.
[\(ESV\)](#)

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